other Francisco" – a slave who is a multidimensional rebel – and a slave system and abolitionist movement that are imbedded in their time and place, the colonial sugar economy. Tomás Gutiérrez Alea also turned to nineteenth-century slave society in *La última cena* (1976), the story of a slave-owner who tries to reenact the Last Supper with his chosen slaves. The 1791 Haitian Revolution and the 1959 Cuban Revolution resonate in the background of the drama and again, a rebel challenges the structural and ideological realities of the slave system. These, and other films, developed the genre of historical film in explicit dialogue with the present.

Other films engaged directly with contemporary realities. Gutiérrez Alea's *Memorias del subdesarrollo* (1968), based on Edmundo Desnoes's novel originally titled *Inconsolable Memories* in English, delves into the life and psyche of an alienated, almost paralyzed, bourgeois intellectual who remains in Cuba after the Revolution, observing the departure of his family and colleagues, the profound changes occurring in society, and the panic of the Missile Crisis with a detached sort of fatalism. The film turned the attention of the world to Cuban cinema. "The reviews published throughout the world following the film's release offer the same laudatory epithets whether they come from New York, Paris, London, or Montevideo. The words 'remarkable,' 'extraordinary,' 'outstanding,' 'perfect' were all applied to the film. 'One of the best films of all times,' David Elliott wrote in 1978 in the *Chicago Sun-Times*, while Arthur Cooper stated in *Newsweek* that '*Memorias del subdesarrollo* is undoubtedly a masterpiece, a complex, ironical and extraordinarily clever film.' " "What is still fascinating today about this film, and what presumably fascinated audiences at the time," Nancy Berthier concluded recently, "is the way Gutiérrez Alea, by means of profoundly original aesthetics, put the issue of the relationship between the intellectual, or quite simply the individual, with the surrounding society in terms of a fundamental dilemma. To choose to be solitary, or in solidarity, to live in distance or fusion?"[22]

Pastor Vega's *Portrait of Teresa* (1979) aimed at "planting a little bomb in every living room" with its sensitive portrayal of a woman struggling with the "triple day" of caring for husband and children, work